Victor Palacios

Director of Data Science and AI Partnerships · USF

How do you end up here?

Still Collecting Degrees

2011

Berkeley

BA in Japanese language and literature

2015

Nagoya

MS in Information Science, in Japan

2021

USF

MS in Data Science

2026

Quantic

MS in Software Eng, under way

What I Will Cover

01 Research, from brains to health

02 The path, and its detours

03 Writing things down in public

04 Partnerships, and one big repo

01

Research

Deception detection

Finding what the brain does when someone lies

Nagoya, 2014

Are action lies unlike speech lies?

Measured with near-infrared light

Forty sentences, three sessions

Published at JCSS in Japan

How the Study Ran

01 Learning

You gesture or speak twenty sentences

02 Recognition

You recall which ones you did which way

03 Lying

You lie about twenty, tell the truth about twenty

"Different lies, different regions."

- Palacios, Saito et al., JCSS 2014

Then Healthcare, 2021

A sensor reads blood sugar all day

Can it tell when you ate?

Healthy participants, not patients

First author, with Woodbridge and Fry

What It Was Really For

Asked vs **Measured**

Did you eat when told? The sensor knew

The Number That Mattered

60%

Baseline

Where we started

89%

After the work

Same data, better target

ICD-10 Coding, 2024

Clinical notes into diagnosis codes

Small open models, not large ones

Over 100,000 notes from MIMIC-IV

Swiss and USF collaboration

What We Benchmarked

Model	Size
Falcon	1B parameters
Phi-3.5	3.5B parameters
Meditron	7B parameters

What Surprised Us

The 1B model held its own

It was not a medical model

LoRA kept quality, cut compute

Small can be good enough

Three Papers, One Habit

Year	Question
2014	What does a lie look like?
2021	Did you really eat?
2024	Can a small model code?

02

The Path

Where I Started

Japanese

Language, literature

vs

Now

Data science and AI

What Japan Taught Me

Language is structured data

Research is mostly patience

Being the outsider is normal

Fluency takes years, not weeks

Industry, in Between

Halo Solutions, working with the CEO

Found overdue patients in 10,000 PDFs

KNIME, teaching six courses

Fraud detection, to a big audience

Two Numbers From Industry

$13M

Revenue identified

Overdue patients found

90k

Subscriber audience

For the fraud talk

What I Do Now

Match students to practicum teams

Mentor those teams for nine months

Teach the SQL certificate course

Career advising, all year

Still a Student Myself

A software engineering master's

Started October 2025

While doing this job

The learning does not stop

03

Writing It Down

mAIstory

Fine-tuned Gemma 2B for stories

An AI storyteller for children

Built through KaggleX mentorship

Code published with the article

The AWS Certificate

Cloud Practitioner, passed first go

Zero cloud experience going in

Only free study materials

Wrote up exactly how

The Numbers From That Post

838

Score

700 is a pass

32

Hours

Across one month

$0

Spent

Free materials only

"The paywall is usually optional."

- A recurring theme

04

Partnerships

The Practicum

Sixteen hours a week

Roughly nine months

Every student, guaranteed

Real problems, real clients

The Scale of It

120+

Companies

Relationships I hold

150+

Students

Taught and mentored

5.67

Of six

My teaching score

Who We Work With

Sector	Partners
Finance	BlackRock
Cloud	AWS and Atlassian
Health	UCSF, Stanford
Mission	The Gates Foundation

Where Our Graduates Land

78%

Take offers in California

Class of 2025

$150k

Median base salary

California offers

What Gets Someone Hired

Work a stranger can look at

One project explained clearly

Curiosity that survives boredom

Not a perfect transcript

05

Ninth Circuit

The Problem

Thousands of opinions a year

Only a fraction are asylum cases

Reading them all is impossible

So the research does not happen

How the Pipeline Works

01

Fetch

Scrape opinions

02

Classify

Asylum or not?

03

Extract

Pull the features

What It Has Built

5,779

Opinions

Growing daily

70+

Features each

With a source quote

26%

Are asylum

The rest filtered

The Trick That Makes It Free

Classify cheaply before extracting

Throw away three quarters first

Roughly four times cheaper

Free-tier models throughout

What It Runs On

Llama 3.3 on a free API tier

Postgres, and a vector index

A daily scheduled job

Total ongoing cost: nothing

Why It Matters

This work was always hand-coded

Now it is searchable

Every claim has its quote

Anyone can read the code

What I Actually Believe

Paths are not straight

I studied literature first

Nothing was wasted

The detour is the edge

The tools are free

A certificate, for nothing

A legal database, free

The barrier is starting

If You Take One Action

Build one small thing publicly

Write down how you did it

Use the free tier for all of it

Then show someone